'Do you want to climb it again? My parents won't mind.'

'No, no. Not after climbing the garden wall. Let's just sit here for a few minutes and talk. I mention the jackfruit tree because it was my favourite place. Do you see that thick branch stretching out over the roof ? Half way along it there's a small hollow in which I used to keep some of my treasures.'

'What kind of treasures?'

'Oh, nothing very valuable. Marbles I'd won. A book I wasn't supposed to read. A few old coins I'd collected. Things came and went. I was a bit of a crow, you know, collecting bright things and putting them away. There was my grandfather's Iron Cross. Well, not my grandfather's exactly, because he was British and the Iron Cross' was a German decoration awarded for bravery during the War - the First World War - when my grandfather fought in France. He got it from a German soldier.'



DO YOU KNOW?

The Param Vir Chakra is the highest wartime gallantry award, given to soldiers of the Indian Armed Forces, for the display of utmost courage and complete selflessness when facing the enemy. Since its inception in 1950, 21 fearless heroes (14 posthumous) have been awarded the medal till January 2019.

'Do you still have it?'

'No', he said, looking her in the eyes. 'I left it in the jackfruit tree.'

'You left it in the tree?'

'Yes, I was so excited at the time, packing and saying goodbye to people and thinking about the ship I was going to sail on that I simply forgot all about it.'

She quietly said, 'It may still be there. In the hollow part of the branch.'

'Yes', he said. 'It's twenty-five years, but it may still be there. Unless someone else found it….'

'Would you like to go and look?'

'I can't climb trees any more.'

'If you can't, I will go and see. You just sit here and wait for me.'

'I've found it!' she cried. 'I've found something!'

And now, barefoot, she ran breathlessly towards him, in her outstretched hand a rusty old medal.

He took it from her and turned it over on his palm.

'Is it the Iron Cross?' she asked eagerly.

'Yes', he said, 'this is it.'

'Now I know why you came. You wanted to see if it was still in the tree.'

'You may be right. I'm not really sure why I came. But you can keep the Cross. You found it, after all.'

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